ON

February 22, as Tejashwi Yadav finished his 20-minute-long speech at a public meeting in Siwan, a stopover 132 km northwest of Patna, during his Jan Vishwas Yatra across the state, almost everyone in the first few rows, young men all, shouted out a request. The message could have been lost in the din, but the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader caught on what his audience wanted—to speak in the local dialect. And Tejashwi obliged, switching to chaste Bhojpuri to say, *'Rauaa logan ke aye ke baa'*—please come [to Patna for the March 3 rally]. On that day, a mega Opposition show, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi is expected to share the stage with RJD president Lalu Prasad and CPI(M) general secretary Sitaram Yechury.

The words Tejashwi chose while speaking in Bhojpuri—a language he is not known to be comfortable in—demonstrated the 34-year-old Yadav scion's politically correct ways. He used *'rauaa'*, a respectable term to address the elders in Bhojpuri, instead of *'tahra'*, which also means you. He also invoked kinship, saying he was a brother of Siwan, where he was addressing the meeting, since his father was from Gopalganj, the neighbouring district.

Tejashwi's impact on the masses, in every meeting he addresses, has been electric. A young crowd that occupies the front spaces cheers him constantly, holding on to every word he utters, repeating everything he says, clapping and shouting slogans. Hundreds of others record his speech on their mobile phones.

At the end of every speech, Tejashwi ties the RJD's green *gamchha* around his head, waves his right hand Gangnam style, as the crowd reciprocates by mimicking his action. Hearts won, approval ratings up, it's mission accomplished.

The Tejashwi Formula

If you thought the exit of Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal (United) from its alliance with the RJD, Congress and Left parties on January 28 would have come as a crisis for Tejashwi, the canny RJD leader has certainly turned it into an opportunity to project himself as an alternative to Nitish, whom he has described as "a man with old thoughts and no new vision". Soon after Nitish's departure, and taking oath again as chief minister of a government in alliance with the BJP and Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha, Tejashwi took credit for honouring his party's pre-poll promise to create 500,000 government jobs, saying he accomplished the feat in his 17-month tenure—from August 2022 to January 2024—as deputy chief minister. The Mahagathbandhan government, in which the RJD held the key departments of education, health, road construction and rural works, he claimed, employed 375,000 people and he had approved another 130,000 jobs in the health department before Nitish ditched them. Tejashwi is unambiguous about the demographic his pitch is aimed at—the Bihar voter aged between 18 and 29, who, at more than 17 million individuals, comprises one-fourth of the electorate.

"Today, all governments in the country, whether in the states or the one at the Centre, cannot shift their focus away from the issue of unemployment," Tejashwi goes on to say. And when the JD(U) derides him for taking credit that the party thinks is undue, Tejashwi reminds them unequivocally: "Why should I not take credit for what we have done as ministers? Though Nitish Kumar, as CM, headed the government, his was the No. 3 party. We are the single-largest party in the current Vidhan Sabha."

An Early Start

The young RJD leader recently concluded a 20-day Jan Vishwas Yatra from February 20 to March 1, covering 33 of Bihar's 38 districts. The Leader of the Opposition was on the road despite the Bihar assembly being in session. His early start came in the wake of an alleged apprehension, which Tejashwi echoed on February 22, about the early dissolution of the Bihar assembly and the CM's plan to hold the state election simultaneously with the Lok Sabha election.

The intent was clear. Tejashwi wanted to hammer home his message about the RJD's priorities—bread and butter issues, and a vision for the youth. Like he did during the trust vote in the assembly, when he demolished Nitish's defence for quitting the *mahagathbandhan* without any apparent rancour, Tejashwi kept his approach during his speeches in the yatra positive as well. Refusing to play victim, and ignoring how the JD(U) made three RJD MLAs switch sides during the trust vote, Tejashwi said, "*Nitishji adarniya the, adarniya hain, adarniya rahenge* (Nitishji was worthy of respect, is worthy of respect and will remain worthy of respect)." The civility is earning Tejashwi goodwill as well as praise for his maturity.

> **"OUR OPPONENTS BLAME US FOR BEING THE M-Y (MUSLIM-YADAV) PARTY. BUT WE HAVE BAAP ALONG WITH M-Y. BAAP STANDS FOR *BAHUJAN, AGDA, AADHI AABADI* AND THE POOR. OURS IS AN A-Z PARTY"**
>
> **TEJASHWI YADAV**
> *RJD leader & Leader of the Opposition, Bihar Assembly*